Concept Note to deliver an Open Science Publishing Solution for Saudi Arabia

F1000

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F1000 | Taylor & Francis

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Proposal Summary

F1000 and Taylor & Francis are delighted to present the following concept note for a unique publishing service and partnership that would support Saudi Arabia in its aims to further medical research and improve health outcomes in the Saudi population, enable efficient sharing of cutting-edge health and social care research, and enhance the reach and potential impact of quality Saudi research among the global research community.

As part of shifts in how research is produced and shared, there has been substantial growth in the adoption of more open and collaborative ways of working among researchers across the globe. The increasing trend to share early research findings (e.g. preprints) and research data, and the appetite for more transparent peer review are fuelled by a demand to accelerate research progress to tackle major societal challenges. This is coupled with the importance of assuring the provenance, integrity and trustworthiness of the latest discoveries. The sponsors of research – notably funding agencies and research institutions – are increasingly seeking ways to harness the opportunities of open and collaborative science to accelerate research impact and deliver return on investment. F1000 and Taylor & Francis have been working in partnership with these key stakeholders to deliver tailored publishing solutions to support the communities that they serve to maximal effect.

Using tried and tested publishing technology and a proven track record in supporting the publication of research focused on today's medical and global health challenges, F1000 has worked in collaboration to support a number of national and global research funders and organisations (e.g. European Commission, Wellcome; UK's National Institute of Health and Social Care Research (NIHR)). F1000 proposes to act as a publishing technology and services partner and deliver an integrated open science publishing solution together with the associated editorial services, focussing on clinical, biomedical and health research in Saudi Arabia. This open science publishing solution will serve several key components, including, but not limited to:

i. **Providing a national publication venue** dedicated to early sharing (preprinting) of Saudi research (as many countries have now developed – e.g. ChinaXiv, JXiv).

ii. **Providing added-value validation checks** to the content posted on the preprint venue (including plagiarism, ethics, and transparency checks amongst others[1]) to provide early markers of validity and assure provenance, addressing a need in the ecosystem to improve research integrity while continuing to support rapid availability of research.

iii. **Supporting authors to share underpinning data** to maximise discoverability of the research data and improve reproducibility, ensuring links to existing data repositories, thereby aligning, and easing compliance with a forthcoming national drive to data sharing.

iv. **Provision of industry standard metadata and author identifiers** across the preprint venue – e.g. ORCID IDs; Institution IDs (Ringold/ROR); Contributor Roles Taxonomy (CRediT); Article and data Digital Object Identifiers (DOIs).

v. **English-language editing services (optional)** to support researchers to disseminate their findings in English.

[1] Typical enhanced content validation checks we can offer include: publishing integrity; research ethics and transparency; quality control and legal responsibility; underlying data, software and code; image checks; methods reproducibility and reporting guidelines.

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vi. **Opportunity to publish policy documents, briefs, guidelines, research reports** ("grey literature") to maximise the potential impact of all types of research outputs. *NB: these would undergo much simpler checks and have not been costed in this proposal.*

vii. **Delivery of a bespoke outreach and engagement programme**, designed for clinical, health and biomedical researchers in Saudi Arabia. This could involve:

   a. **Multi-channel awareness campaigns**, strategically phased to raise awareness and communicate benefits to researchers of publishing in this new venue. Targeted messaging will be disseminated through digital platforms, academic conferences, and collaborations with research organizations, emphasizing the importance of preprints and their impact on the research ecosystem.

   b. **Dedicated communication channels**, such as newsletters, webinars, and social media platforms, as well as our F1000 and Taylor & Francis channels where appropriate, to engage with researchers, disseminate updates, and share success stories. These channels will provide a forum for researchers to ask questions, share experiences, and stay informed about the latest developments in preprint adoption.

   c. **Capacity building**, through working with Saudi researchers to deliver, for example, informational webinars on open research practices, on sharing open data in medical and health research, and research integrity training.

viii. **Flexible and simplified routes for authors to take their preprint forward through the publication process** in Taylor & Francis's extensive and widely indexed medical, health and other relevant subject portfolio (e.g. Dove Medical Press; Future Science Group; Cogent) - as well as to journals from other publishers. F1000 / Taylor & Francis could also launch a dedicated and linked national journal focussed on Saudi-based research outputs to maximise the breadth of clinical and biomedical research from Saudi Arabia that can be published in a peer reviewed journal. *NB: These additional services have not been costed in our estimates but further detail is provided in the 'Optional and Additional Services' section below*.

This open science preprint venue would deliver maximal discoverability and reach to research outputs, bring efficiencies to the Saudi Arabian research system, reduce research waste by increasing publication space for a wider range of outputs, and thereby deliver significant return on investment.

Indicative and Estimated Costs

Based upon the description provided in this concept note and from what we understand are the basic requirements, the preprint venue offer would cost in the region of $650,000 to set up (one off fee), a significant proportion of which covers the provision of a dual language environment of English and Arabic (with the publications themselves in English language). This would be in addition to an annual management and technology service charge of circa $300,000 per annum to include an agreed level of customisation and maintenance of the dual language content on the site. Once delivered, and subject to a change request procedure, we would be able to evolve the open science publishing solution as its vision and strategy develops, with F1000 as a development partner.

We would normally expect such a Platform contract for technology and services to run for five years with options to extend and hence our estimated costs are based on such a term.

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Given the vision is to cover content charges, we have estimated likely content volumes based on national historical publication data, as well as past experience of launching similar venues (see **Table 1**). We have therefore included content publishing charges for the rigorous prepublication checks on all the preprints, ranging from ethics and integrity checks to open research checks around the sharing of the underpinning research data, code and materials and adherence to relevant community reporting standards – these costs are laid out in **Table 2** below. As described above, we have also included costs for an outreach, engagement, and capacity building programme.

Without the content volume fees (if you wish to treat these fees differently), the total over the 6-year period (development of the preprint server followed by 5 years of infrastructure support and evolution, and outreach and engagement activity) would total $2,967,701. Including preprint processing fees based on our estimated volumes over the 5 years, would total $10,358,034.

At this point, we have not included the costs of subsequent peer review, or of publishing the fully peer reviewed articles in their final journal destination but can provide such estimates if required.

Table 1: Projected Publishing Volumes

Year	Projected Total Publications*	Projected Preprint Publications	% of Total Publications
2025	17,962	539	3%
2026	21,026	1262	6%
2027	24,612	2215	9%
2028	28,811	3457	12%
2029	33,726	5059	15%

* *NB: Projected Total Publications are based on Dimensions data for research affiliated to Saudi Arabia, in biomedical and clinical sciences up until 2023, and forecast using the current Compound Annual Growth Rate.*

We are happy to rework publication assumptions (and associated costs) in collaboration with partners in Saudi Arabia, based on further context around current preprinting appetite and national plans to drive activity in this area.

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Table 2: Indicative and Estimated Costs

	Number of preprints	Build Costs	Annual maintenance + customisations	Outreach & Engagement Fee	Preprint content publication	Total Annual Fee
		One-time fee	Annual fee	Annual fee	Annual fee	Build costs; Annual maintenance and customisations; Outreach & engagement; Preprint verification
2024 (Year 0)	*0*	$650,000	$0	$0	$0	**$650,000**
2025 (Year 1)	*Up to 540*	$0	$300,000	$138,160	$266,765	**$704,925**
2026 (Year 2)	*Up to 1,300*	$0	$309,000	$144,200	$680,933	**$1,134,133**
2027 (Year 3)	*Up to 2,200*	$0	$318,270	$164,200	$1,199,733	**$1,682,203**
2028 (Year 4)	*Up to 3,500*	$0	$327,818	$144,200	$2,060,429	**$2,532,447**
2029 (Year 5)	*Up to 5,100*	$0	$337,653	$134,200	$3,182,472	**$3,654,325**
					TOTAL	**$10,358,034**

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Optional and Additional Services

There are a number of additional services and options that we have not formally included in this proposal, which we could provide further detail on (including costings) if there is interest following further discussion. A couple of options are listed here.

Author editing support

We work closely with a third party to provide the option of English-language editing support on submissions to relevant authors. Based on our experience in the region, we estimate approximately 10% of authors may benefit from such a service and have provided an idea of associated costs in **Table 3** based on the volumes used in the main proposal. However, please note that these are indicative costs only, as these would be directly linked to usage and consequently charged on a 'pay for what you use' model.

Table 3: Additional English-language Editing Costs

Year	Costs based on 10% of projected publications
2025	$56,203
2026	$131,581
2027	$231,033
2028	$360,598
2029	$527,643
Total	**$1,307,058**

Launch of a new dedicated and linked national journal

F1000 / Taylor & Francis could work with the Saudi partners to launch a dedicated national journal focussed on publishing peer-reviewed Saudi-based research outputs to ensure that clinical and biomedical research from Saudi Arabia is shared as openly as possible. Such a journal would have its own unique ISSN where preprinted content can move directly into transparent peer review to enhance integrity, and fully Open Access publication (with open and permissive licenses) to support use and reuse. As with any new publishing venue, applications for inclusion in bibliographic indexers would need to be sought post-launch once adequate volumes are achieved. Features could include, but not limited to:

- **a very wide range of peer reviewed article options** tailored to support the life and medical sciences, including Study Protocols, Clinical Practice Articles, Method Articles, Case Reports, Systematic Reviews to maximise the breadth of research outputs that are published in a peer reviewed journal.
- **the ability to maximise the full versioning capability of the platform to enable the publication and currency of 'living' systematic reviews and 'living' evidence** to accelerate improvements in clinical practice as the latest evidence becomes available.

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- **opportunity to provide tailored plain language summaries of research findings** to maximise discoverability and use among specific groups and alongside specific content (e.g. for policymakers, patients; health care professionals).

Conclusions

We are very much looking forward to talking further about the ways F1000 and Taylor & Francis can support the reach and impact Saudi Arabian research and improve health outcomes in the Saudi population.

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Our Credentials

Part of the Taylor & Francis Group since 2020, F1000 is a pioneer in providing open research publishing venues that make all the outputs of research – across all its forms and formats – as discoverable, accessible, useable and reusable as possible. Working across F1000 and Taylor & Francis open access offerings provides partners with comprehensive ways to serve their research communities.

F1000 have extensive partnerships with research funders, research performing organisations and scholarly societies (see some examples in **Table 4**), often providing tailored solutions for medical & health research (see some examples of partnerships in the below table). Combined with Taylor & Francis's breadth of partnerships in the Arab Region and established links with research institutions (including Saudi Digital Library, Qatar National library and Egyptian Knowledge Bank) – we are uniquely placed to deliver publishing expertise and solutions tailored to the needs and ambitions of Saudi Arabia.

Table 4: F1000 open research publishing solution partners

Organisation	Research sector	Disciplinary coverage	Year launched
Qatar National Library	Research consortium	All disciplines	2023
American Nuclear Society	Scholarly society	Physical Sciences	2023
European Commission	Research funder	All disciplines	2021
MAHE	Research performing institution	All disciplines	2021
National Institute of Health Research (NIHR)	Research funder	Applied health and clinical research	2021
University of Tsukuba	Research performing institution	All disciplines	2020
Special Programme for Research & Training in Tropical Diseases (TDR, World Health Organisation)	Research funder	Infectious diseases, life sciences	2019
Association of Medical Research Charities	Research funder	Medical & life sciences; ethics & policy	2019
Health Research Board Ireland	Research funder	Medical & life sciences	2018
National Centre for 3Rs	Research funder/sponsor	Medical & life sciences	2018
Institute of Child Health, University College London	Research performing institution	Medical & life sciences	2018
Science Foundation Africa (formerly the African Academy of Sciences (AAS))	Research funder/sponsor	All disciplines	2018
Bill & Melinda Gates Foundation	Research funder	Agriculture & nutrition; education; life sciences	2017
Wellcome Trust	Research funder	Medical & life sciences; medical humanities & social sciences	2016
Sidra Medicine	Research performing institution	Medical & life sciences	2015
Médecins Sans Frontières	Research sponsor/advocacy organisation	International development	2014

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